3. Animal Shelters

Can you tell ?

- The cat is lying in wait for someone. Who is that ?
- What has frightened the crows ? Why are they trying to frighten the cat away?

Can you tell ?

- What do birds use to build their nests ?
- Which animals live in burrows ?
- Where do the hens we keep live ? Who builds their shelter ?

• Why do we need houses ?

Very cold weather, gusty winds, scorching sun, heavy rains can cause us great discomfort. We live in houses to protect ourselves from them. A house also protects us from thefts.

Some people live very close to forests. They have to face the threat of wild animals. A house protects them from the wild animals, too.

Like us, do animals also need shelters? Some animals do. They build shelters for themselves. Some other animals find shelter in safe places in the environment.

A new term :
Shelter : a safe place where one is protected from any danger. A place where one is protected from the sun, rain, wind, etc.

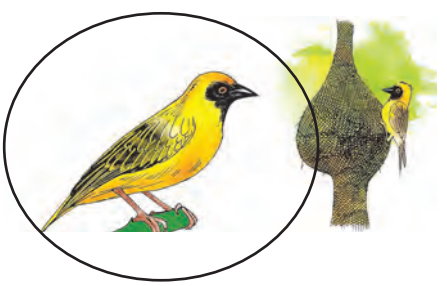
• Animals who build shelters for themselves

You must have seen birds' nests. Nests are shelters that birds build. Birds are afraid of animals that eat eggs. So they need a safe place to lay their eggs.

Baby birds come out of the eggs. There are animals

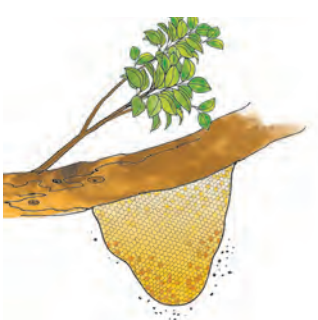
that eat these young birds. The young birds are too weak to defend themselves. The nest keeps the young ones safe. That is why birds build nests. They use things like grass, straw and twigs to build nests. They may even use cotton wool, and pieces of thread and string. This makes the nest soft and warm inside.

But the nests of all birds are not all alike.



Birds choose convenient places to build nests. Look at the weaver bird. It chooses a thorny tree which has some branches hanging over water. It builds its nest on the highest of these branches. Animals that eat eggs find it difficult to reach this nest.

The tailor bird is smaller than a sparrow. It selects a plant with bigger leaves and builds its nest by stitching the leaves together. It uses a fine tendril to stitch them together. This little nest is big enough for the little tailor bird.



Some insects also build their own shelters. For example, honey bees build their honeycombs on trees or under the roof of an overhanging cliff.

Rats and mice live underground in fields. They dig into the soil and make holes and burrows to live in.

Rats and mice also live in areas where people live. They make holes in the walls or under the floors in houses. They mostly take shelter in mud houses and not in those built with cement. That is because they cannot dig holes into cement construction.

• Animals that find ready shelters in the surroundings

Some animals do not make any efforts to build a shelter. They simply look around for a safe place. Some doves and pigeons live in forests. Some live in small hollows in high cliffs. Some live near our houses. They find shelter in gaps in walls.

Tigers, leopards, hyenas live in caves.

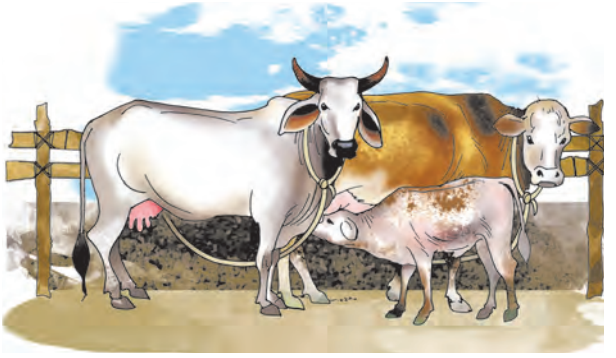
Some types of bats live in tall trees. But some live in dark caverns in mountains. Or, they look for shelter in old, deserted, tumble-down buildings.

Do you know?

It is believed that a cobra lives in an anthill. But that is not true. Anthills are built by ants, not by a cobra. The cobras live in holes.

• Shelters for domestic animals

When people keep animals, they build shelters for them.



A cowshed is built for cows.

The shelter built for hens is called a chicken coop or henhouse.

The shelter for a horse is called a stable.

What we have learnt –

- Animals need a shelter to protect themselves from the cold, wind, sun and rain.
- Some animals build their own shelters.
- Some animals look for ready shelters in their surroundings.
- We build shelters for the animals we keep.

Always remember –

Is it right to keep animals in cages for our pleasure ?
No, let them live in their natural surroundings.

Exercises

A. What's the solution ?

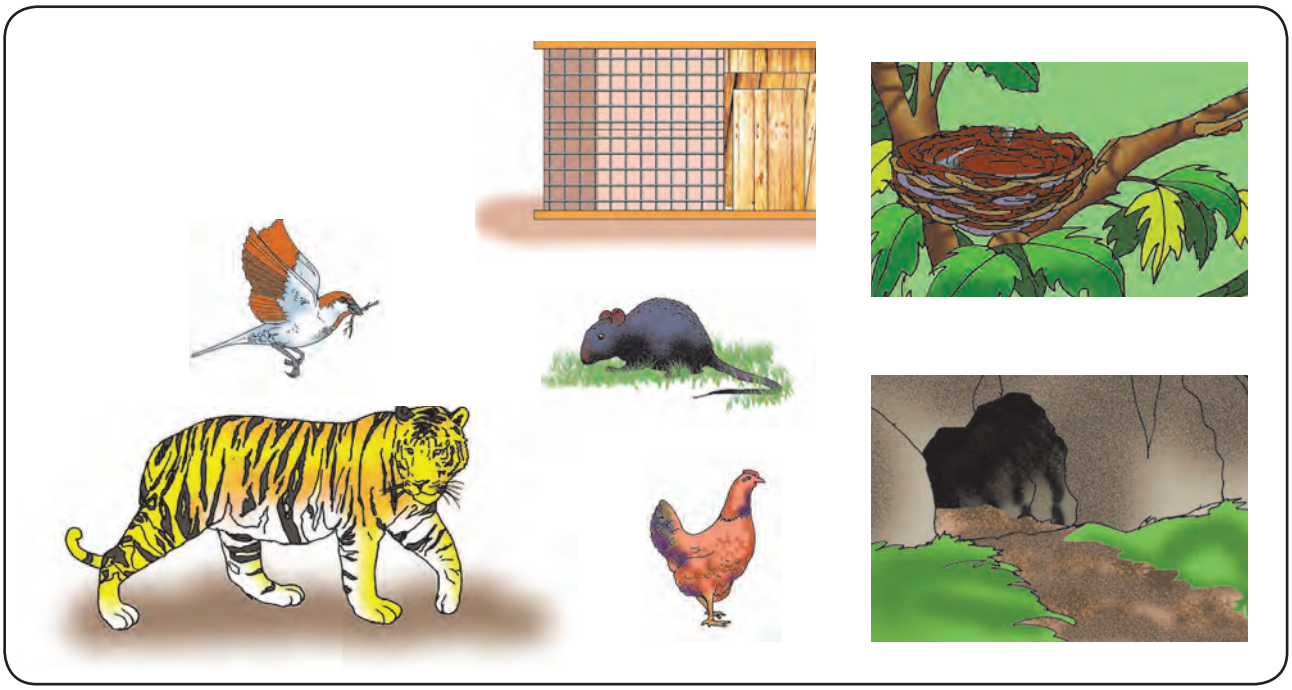
The population of birds in several cities is falling. What could be the reason for that ? Their number should increase again.

B. Think and tell.

(1) What material do ants use to make anthills ?

(2) Some doves and some pigeons have left the jungles and have come to live in areas where people live. Some mice have also done so. What could be the reasons for that ?

(3) In the picture below, match the animals and their shelters.



C. Fill in the blanks.

(1) The nests of birds are not all ..... .

(2) The ..... bird is smaller than the sparrow.

(3) Some animals do not make any ..... to build shelters for themselves.

(4) Tigers, leopards and ..... live in caves in mountains.

(5) The shelter made for a horse is called a ..... .

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D. Answer the following questions.

(1) What does the tailor bird use to stitch its nest ?

(2) What makes it difficult for animals that eat eggs to reach a weaver bird's nest ?

(3) How do birds make their nests soft and warm ?

(4) Why do mice and rats not enter houses built with cement ?

(5) Where do bats find shelter besides dark caverns ?

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